

STAR Sample Responses

PRIME · Land it. Negotiate it. Own it.

Worked examples for the most common competency questions. Don't memorise these — study the structure, then swap in your own stories. Set the scene, state your responsibility, focus on YOUR actions, land on a measurable result.

“Tell me about a time you worked in a team to deliver something.”

Step	Sample response
S — Situation	In my final year, our four-person team had to produce a market analysis for a real local business as our capstone project.
T — Task	I was responsible for the competitor research and for pulling everyone's sections into one coherent report.
A — Action	I set up a shared tracker with deadlines for each section, ran a 15-minute check-in twice a week, and when one teammate fell behind I rebalanced tasks early rather than letting it slip.
R — Result	We submitted two days early and scored 78% — the business owner adopted two of our recommendations.

Why it works: Specific role in the team, a problem handled early, and a result the listener can verify.

“Describe a challenging situation and how you resolved it.”

Step	Sample response
S — Situation	During my retail job, a delivery failure left us without stock for a weekend promotion that had already been advertised.
T — Task	As the most senior person on shift, I needed to manage frustrated customers and protect the promotion's sales.
A — Action	I arranged stock transfers from two nearby branches, offered rain-checks at the promotional price, and briefed the team on a single consistent message for customers.
R — Result	We recovered around 80% of the expected promotional sales and had zero formal complaints that weekend.

Why it works: Calm ownership under pressure plus a quantified recovery — exactly what the question is probing for.

“Give an example of a time you showed leadership.”

Step	Sample response
S — Situation	Our student society's annual careers fair was three weeks away when the organiser dropped out unexpectedly.
T — Task	Nobody was officially responsible — so I volunteered to take it on rather than let it be cancelled.
A — Action	I split the workload across five volunteers by strength, renegotiated with the venue, and personally called every employer contact to reconfirm attendance.
R — Result	The fair ran on schedule with 18 employers — two more than the previous year — and 200+ attendees.

Why it works: Leadership without a title: stepping up, organising others, delivering a better result than the baseline.

“Tell me about a time you had to meet a tight deadline.”

Step	Sample response
S — Situation	In my internship, a client moved a report deadline forward by a week with half the analysis still outstanding.
T — Task	I had to deliver my section early without dropping quality on my other commitments.
A — Action	I listed everything outstanding, agreed with my manager what could be de-scoped, blocked two mornings of focus time, and flagged one risk early instead of hiding it.
R — Result	My section was delivered a day ahead of the new deadline and the client meeting went ahead as planned.

Why it works: Shows prioritisation, communication with the manager, and honesty about trade-offs — not just “I worked late.”

“Describe a time something went wrong because of you. What did you learn?”

Step	Sample response
S — Situation	Early in my part-time job I double-booked two customer appointments because I was keeping notes in two places.
T — Task	I had to fix the immediate clash and make sure it couldn't happen again.
A — Action	I called both customers immediately, apologised and rebooked the one who was more flexible — then moved all scheduling into one calendar with confirmation reminders.
R — Result	No repeat in over a year, and my manager rolled the one-calendar system out to the whole team.

Why it works: Owns the mistake without excuses, fixes the system not just the symptom — the learning is the result.

Build your own

- Pick the competencies in your target job description — prepare one story per competency.
- Vary your examples: don't lean on the same project five times.
- Quantify every Result you can. Numbers are remembered; adjectives are not.
- Say your stories out loud. Written STAR and spoken STAR are different skills.